



M/J Critical Thinking Skills: Teacher Manual

FLORIDA COURSE #1700100 · FULL YEAR, GRADES 6–8 · 2026–2027



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COURSE M/J Critical Thinking Skills	FLORIDA COURSE CODE 1700100 (M/J Critical Thinking, Problem Solving, and Learning Strategies)	GRADE BAND Middle School, Grades 6–8
DELIVERY On-Demand (asynchronous), full year; also offered Live on the VR campus — 4-day compression addressed below	MODULES 5 (Preparing · Acting · Thinking · Reading · Arguing Like an Intellectual)	MANUAL BUILT FROM The finished course build (all 5 modules, every lesson/assignment/VR/wrapper file read in full), the 2026–2027 syllabus, and the CPALMS course page, 2026-07-16

How to use this manual. Sections 1–13 follow the required Optima Teacher Manual structure, with one additional section (placed after Section 10) on adapting the course to a Live, 4-day-per-week class. Read Section 1 first for the shape of the course, then use the table of contents to jump to what you need: rubrics before you grade a project, the standards map before a parent conference, the sensitive-content scripts before Module 2 or Module 5 open. Every fact in this manual is read directly out of the built course — every lesson, assignment, VR activity, wrapper quiz, and capstone file was opened and reviewed. Anything the manual could not confirm directly from the build, or that the build itself is missing, is marked [\[VERIFY\]](#) .

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1 HOW THIS COURSE WORKS

The course moves scholars through five modules, each a different facet of intellectual life: preparing to learn, acting on good judgment in everyday situations, thinking scientifically, reading closely, and arguing well. Every module pairs each topic with exactly the same three-part unit — **one interactive lesson, one written assignment, one VR activity** — and three of the five modules (3, 4, 5) build those units toward a single capstone project. The shape repeats; the topic changes.

Course at a glance

MODULE	TOPICS (LESSON+ASSIGNMENT+VR UNITS)	CAPSTONE	COURSE PLACEMENT
M1 Preparing Like an Intellectual	4 — time mgmt/goals, active reading/memory/notes, research & presenting, collaboration/stress/test prep	None	Q1, weeks 1--~13 (shared with M2, no explicit week split in the build)
M2 Acting Like an Intellectual	8 (+2 short section prefaces) — 6 soft-skills topics, then 2 “normativity” topics (facts/opinions, moral facts)	None	Q1–Q2, remainder of weeks 1–13
M3 Thinking Like an Intellectual	9 (+1 Excel bridge lesson between topics 4 and 5) — explanation freeze, scientific reasoning, degrees of belief, evidence, Bayesian updating, fallacies	The Good Life Experiment — a week(s)-long self-experiment; target Feb 26, Q3	Weeks 14–24
M4 Reading Like an Intellectual	8 — previewing, questioning, big picture/details, ambiguity, inference, structure, synthesis, academic integrity	Annotated Bibliography — a VR research library with a guided tour; target Apr 30	Weeks 25–32
M5 Arguing Like an Intellectual	3 — basics of argumentation, evaluating arguments, reviewing & refining	The Disputatio (course final) — a defended argument in a VR arena; target May 21	Weeks 33–36

[VERIFY] PACING. Modules 3, 4, and 5 carry explicit week ranges in the syllabus. Modules 1 and 2 do not — the built lessons are topic-paced (no “Week 1 / Week 2” labels), and the only calendar clue in the build is the Module 1 outro quiz asking what’s changed “since three weeks ago,” implying Module 1 targets roughly 3–4 weeks, leaving Module 2’s 8 topics + 2 prefaces to fill the remaining ~9–10 weeks before Module 3 begins in Week 14. Confirm exact per-topic pacing for M1/M2 before publishing a week-by-week calendar to students; the Section 10-adjacent Live-class guide below paces by topic rather than by fixed week for this reason.

A typical lesson, walked top to bottom

Example: *Lesson 1: Time Management and Goal Setting* (Module 1). Every interactive lesson in the course follows this same shape:

- 1 **Metadata strip.** Quarter/module and lesson topic sit at the top so a student always knows where they are. (No lesson in the build carries an explicit minute estimate — see the workflow note in Section 10.)
- 2 **Today's Focus.** A one- or two-sentence hook in an encouraging, direct voice (“Hey there, scholars!...”).
- 3 **Objectives (“By the end of this lesson you will be able to...”).** Two or three numbered, student-voice “I will be able to” statements.
- 4 **What You Need.** A short materials list, always ending with the VR headset line for the paired VR activity.
- 5 **Widget 1 — an ungraded check-in.** A quick, non-evaluative “how are you feeling about this” click-through; every choice gets a real, tailored response. No wrong answer.
- 6 **Teaching content,** in 2–4 numbered “Part” sections, usually built around one worked example or story (a real historical case in Module 3, a heist-movie analogy in Module 2, a mock detective mystery in places).
- 7 **One AI-awareness callout,** styled as a gold/red “⚠️ WORTH KNOWING” box, appearing once per lesson, always naming specifically what AI can and cannot do for that lesson’s skill. Never a directive to use a specific tool. See Section 3.
- 8 **Widget 2 (and sometimes 3) — a genuinely evaluative “Try It.”** Two to four scenario rows, correct/incorrect color-coded feedback, a substantive explanation on both right and wrong answers, a Reset button.
- 9 **What You’ll Do Next.** Always exactly two links: the paired written Assignment and the paired VR activity.
- 10 **The Takeaway.** A short closing paragraph, no dramatic closer.

Where's the graded touchpoint? Never on the lesson page itself. The lesson’s two widgets are self-checks with instant feedback and produce no Canvas submission. The graded work is the paired written Assignment (a Word document, uploaded via the OneDrive tab) and the paired VR activity (a snapshot + a short recorded walkthrough, completion-scored). See Section 2.

A typical topic cycle

Because the build is topic-paced rather than day-labeled, use this shape as the "week" for any topic in any module. On the On-Demand side a scholar moves through all three steps at their own pace inside the quarter; a facilitator running a Live section maps this onto four class days (Section 10-adjacent).

STEP	WHAT THE STUDENT DOES	GRADED?	TIER
1. Lesson	Reads/works the interactive lesson: hook, content, two self-check widgets, the AI callout	No direct submission	n/a
2. Written Assignment	Produces a Word document (reflection, analysis, research summary, argument, etc.), uploaded via OneDrive	Yes — batch-graded	Tier 2
3. VR Activity	Builds a small staged scene in a student-chosen setting, captures a snapshot, records a short walkthrough video, sometimes writes a short reflection	Yes — completion only	Tier 1

Modules 3, 4, and 5 thread a fourth, cumulative layer through every topic cycle: each topic's VR activity is also one numbered stage of that module's persistent capstone build (a VR lab in Module 3, a VR research library in Module 4, a VR disputatio arena in Module 5). The capstone itself — the tour/defense video plus its companion document(s) — is the module's one Tier 3 assessment.

Major assessments

ASSESSMENT	WHERE	TIER	WHAT IT ASKS	TEACHER TIME
Written Assignment	Every topic, all 5 modules (~26 formally graded across the course; see Section 7)	2	A Word document: a reflection, an analysis, a categorization task, a short argument, etc., specific to that topic	~1–2 min/student, batch-checked against a compact rubric
VR Activity	Every topic, all 5 modules (32 total)	1	Staged scene + snapshot + a short recorded walkthrough (Video MyRec-equivalent)	~0 hrs — completion check only
Module Intro / Outro Wrapper	Once each, all 5 modules (10 total)	4 (survey)	Essential question, confidence rating, "what's still unclear," virtue reflection	~15–20 min cohort triage per module
The Good Life Experiment (Capstone)	Module 3	3	A 9-stage VR lab tour (6–10 min video, six research-paper sections) + a one-page Word reflection	~8–12 hrs / 500 students, spread across the project window
Annotated Bibliography (Capstone)	Module 4	3	A 6-entry annotated bibliography (Word) + a VR research-library guided tour (6–9 min video)	~8–12 hrs
The Disputatio (Course Final Capstone)	Module 5	3	A defended-argument document + a VR arena presentation (7–10 min video) + a short AI Self-Assessment	~8–12 hrs, the heaviest single grading window in the course

[VERIFY] MODULE 3, ASSIGNMENT 1. Lesson 3.1 ("Explanation Freeze") tells students their paired assignment is "Assignment 1: Thawing Explanation Freeze," but no `assignment-3-1` file exists in the built course folder — the assignment files begin at Assignment 2 (Handwashing Infographic). Confirm whether this file is missing, misplaced, or was never built, and add it before publishing Module 3.

2 UNGRADED INTERACTIVES & THE INTRO/OUTRO WRAPPERS

Ungraded interactive activities

Every lesson carries two widgets: a non-evaluative "quick check-in" (click any option, get a real, tailored response — no wrong answer) and a genuinely evaluative "Try It" (2–4 scenario rows, correct/incorrect color feedback, an explanation either way, a Reset button). Both live only on the lesson page. They produce **no Canvas submission** and need **no grading**.

Treat these as formation, not busywork to chase. A student who skips a widget shows up indirectly — in a thinner written Assignment or a shakier VR reflection — never as a missing grade. Do not build a tracking system for widget completion; it doesn't exist in the gradebook and shouldn't exist in your workflow either.

Intro/outro wrappers are Canvas Quizzes in survey mode

Every one of the 10 module intro/outro pages is explicitly built and labeled — in the file itself — as a **Canvas Quiz in survey mode, ungraded**, not a wiki page. That's deliberate: it turns the essential question, the confidence check, and the virtue reflection into **sortable cohort data** across all 500 students in a module, instead of prose you'd read one at a time.

ITEM	CAPTURES	WHAT YOU DO WITH IT
Module Intro (5–6 items, every module)	First answer to the essential question; a self-select of which lesson topics the student most needs; a confidence baseline (5-point Likert); a group-work opt-in with a "Group Covenant" commitment; one module-specific extra (e.g., a belief the student holds with less than full confidence in M3; a first reaction to the capstone project in M4/M5)	Sort opt-ins to arrange project partners. First-answer responses are your baseline for growth.
Module Outro (5–7 items, every module)	Refined essential-question answer (compare to Intro); post-module confidence rating; "what's still unclear" (free text); a virtue-reflection multiple choice + one-sentence explanation; module-specific extras (M4 asks students to describe their VR library; M5, as the course-final outro, adds a whole-course reflection, an "AI question," and advice for next year's student)	The confidence rating is your early-warning signal. The "still unclear" free text tells you what to re-teach.

The highest-leverage 20 minutes per module: at each module's outro, spend 15–20 minutes triaging responses before your next announcement.

- 1 Sort the confidence-rating column. Pull every "not yet confident" response to the top.
- 2 Scan the "still unclear" free text for repeats. Three or more students naming the same confusion is a re-teach signal, not an individual problem.
- 3 Act: a targeted announcement (Section 9), an Ignite AI-drafted nudge to the low-confidence cluster (Section 4), or an individual message to a student who named something specific and personal.

[VERIFY] THE GROUP-WORK COVENANT. Every module intro offers a group-work opt-in ("complete one shared submission with the same rubric as solo students") tied to "the substantive assignment in this module." In Modules 3–5 that's unambiguously the capstone. In Modules 1–2, which have no single capstone, the built quiz doesn't say which of the four/eight assignments the covenant applies to. Decide and communicate this before Module 1 opens — a reasonable default is the module's most substantive item (M1: Assignment 3, research & presentation; M2: whichever the facilitator designates).

3 AI & VR IN THIS COURSE (STUDENT-FACING)

AI: awareness, not required tool use

Every one of the course's ~32 lessons carries exactly one AI-awareness callout, and every one follows the same pattern: name specifically what an AI tool can do for this task, name specifically what it cannot or should not do, and stop. None require a specific tool; several name real tools generically for orientation only (Microsoft Copilot, ChatGPT, Gemini are named once, in Lesson 1.1, purely as examples of "an AI assistant"). Representative examples, spanning the course's arc:

- **M1 (Lesson 1, goal-setting):** "AI assistants can polish a goal's wording... They cannot tell you what matters to you."
- **M2 (Lesson 8, moral facts):** "AI chatbots are often trained to dodge moral claims... ask the AI for the reasoning on both sides... then make the moral judgment yourself, with reasons."
- **M3 (Lesson 4, degrees of belief):** "AI assistants speak with confidence even when they're guessing... Always ask the AI... 'how confident are you... and what would lower your confidence?'"
- **M4 (Lesson 8, academic integrity):** "If you use an AI tool to draft text and submit it as your own, that's the same kind of integrity violation as copying from a website without crediting... any AI-generated text you use should be acknowledged the same way you'd cite any other source." — the most direct AI-integrity statement in the course.
- **M5 (the Disputatio's "Great Conversation Method"):** a full methodology teaching students to use AI to map a topic's landscape, then verify every load-bearing claim themselves — "AI's job is to map the landscape; YOUR job is to walk it and check the ground." The Disputatio capstone's third deliverable is an **AI Self-Assessment** (what the student used AI for, what they built themselves, what they want to become good at vs. depend on AI for) — a reflection, never a requirement to use AI, and fully consistent with "awareness, not required use."

VR: what the student actually does

Every VR activity in the course is one solo, self-contained session in a setting the student chooses ("a Location that fits how YOU work"). The pattern is consistent:

- 1 Enter a chosen setting (in Modules 3–5 this is the same persistent setting across the whole module — a research lab, a research library, a disputatio arena; in Modules 1–2 each activity is typically its own one-off scene).
- 2 Place a small number of objects, sticky notes, or whiteboard entries to stage the week's thinking (a matrix, a mnemonic, a counterargument wall, an evidence board).
- 3 Capture the scene: a snapshot, and usually a short narrated video walkthrough.
- 4 Sometimes, a short written reflection connecting the scene to the lesson.

VR activities are completion-scored, not rubric-graded — confirm a staged scene, a submitted snapshot, and a recorded walkthrough are present, not a polished production. In Modules 3, 4, and 5 the VR activities also accumulate into the capstone build, so a light mid-module glance at VR submissions doubles as an early look at how the project is shaping up.

[VERIFY] VR platform naming. The built course names the current VR platform ("ENGAGE") and its feature-specific vocabulary (Locations, IFX, Video MyRec, Spatial MyRec) directly and repeatedly — explicitly in every VR file across Modules 1, 2, and 3, and in two spots in Module 4 (the Library Foyer activity and the capstone's Shelf 6 placeholder); Module 5 avoids the platform's name itself but still uses its feature-specific terms (IFX, MyRec) throughout. Since Optima is moving to a new, unannounced VR platform and course content is meant to stay platform-agnostic until it's announced, this entire module set will need a terminology pass (platform name and feature-specific nouns genericized) before it is fully compliant. This is a content-revision task for the curriculum team, not something this manual can fix — flagging it here so a facilitator teaching the course today knows the student-facing pages currently name a platform that is scheduled to change, and can describe VR to students and families in platform-neutral terms (a VR headset and "the VR platform") regardless of what the pages currently say.

4 USING IGNITE AI TO SUPPORT STUDENTS

VERIFY BEFORE RELYING ON THIS SECTION. Ignite AI's exact feature names, buttons, and availability change with Canvas releases and with what Optima has turned on for this course. Confirm the current feature set in Optima's live Canvas instance before promising a specific capability; the guidance below is written functionally so it should survive small interface changes, but no feature listed here is guaranteed enabled by default.

At 500 students to one facilitator, Ignite AI is what makes individualized attention possible without individualized time. The rule governing every use below is the same: **AI drafts, the teacher decides.** You always read, edit, and own anything that reaches a student or a family. AI is never used to rank, surveil, or auto-penalize a student.

Drafting individualized feedback

Ask Ignite AI to draft a short comment on a capstone submission (the Good Life Experiment video, the Annotated Bibliography, the Disputatio) given the student's work and the rubric level you've already chosen. You edit it before posting. This is where the course carries real per-student written feedback (Tier 3), and exactly where a faster first draft matters most.

Summarizing wrapper analytics

With only 5 modules and no discussion forums in this build (see Section 7), your analytics load is lighter than a weekly-cadence course — but each module's outro wrapper still carries ~500 confidence ratings and free-text "still unclear" responses. Ask Ignite AI to summarize the outro's common confusions before you triage them by hand (Section 2); it turns a skim of 500 rows into a two-minute read, which you then verify yourself against the sorted data.

Surfacing students who need a nudge

Low confidence on an outro, a missed written assignment, or a gap in VR-activity completion are your signals. Ask Ignite AI to draft a warm, specific check-in message ("I noticed your confidence on the evidence-and-fallacies unit was low — want to walk through the Bayesian-updating example together at office hours?"). You edit and send it yourself.

Generating practice variants

For a student who needs another rep on a Tier 1 skill — say, placing evidence on the 5-point strength scale in Module 3, Lesson 7 — ask Ignite AI to generate a second scenario in the same shape as the lesson's widget. Review it for accuracy before sharing; the widgets

themselves are not editable, so a fresh practice example has to come from you.

Communicating with families

Ask Ignite AI to draft a clear, kind summary of a student's progress, or to translate a message, before a family conference. This is especially useful ahead of the Module 5 Disputatio, where a family may want to know in advance what contested topic their student chose (Section 13).

Every one of the five uses above is governed by **coach, not catch** (Section 8): Ignite AI helps you find students who need support sooner, not students to penalize. It never drafts a punitive message, never flags a student for suspected AI misuse without your independent judgment, and never decides a grade on its own.

5 GRADING CATEGORIES & CANVAS GRADEBOOK SETUP

The course's grading weights are already set in the published syllabus and should be treated as ground truth — do not recompute them:

WEIGHT	CATEGORY	MAPS TO
50%	Weekly written assignments	Tier 2
30%	Module projects & the Disputatio final	Tier 3
20%	VR campus activities	Tier 1

The module intro/outro wrappers (Tier 4, survey/completion) are not one of the syllabus's three graded categories. Track them via the Canvas module-progress/requirements view as a completion signal, not as a percentage of the final grade — this keeps the published 50/30/20 split exact.

Step-by-step Canvas setup

- 1 Create three assignment groups: **Weekly Written Assignments** (50%), **Module Projects & the Disputatio Final** (30%), **VR Campus Activities** (20%). Set group weights in Canvas to these exact percentages.
- 2 Set the grading scheme to points within each group, weighted by group at the total-grade level (standard Canvas weighted-groups setup).
- 3 Build all 10 module intro/outro quizzes as **ungraded surveys** (Quizzes → New Quiz → Survey, or Classic Quizzes → Survey type) so they generate analytics but carry no points and sit outside the three graded groups.
- 4 Set the late/missing policy per the syllabus: no penalty for an individual missed due date; a zero for anything not completed by quarter's end; a 10% deduction for anything submitted in a quarter's final 14 days.
- 5 Mark every VR activity as **completion-scored** (full points for a submitted snapshot + walkthrough meeting the stated criteria; Canvas "complete/incomplete" grading type works well here).
- 6 Use the module-progress/requirements view as your at-a-glance signal for who has and hasn't touched the ungraded lesson widgets and wrapper quizzes.

Gradebook map

ITEM	ASSIGNMENT GROUP	SUGGESTED POINTS	GRADING METHOD
Weekly Written Assignment (~26 across the course)	Weekly Written Assignments	20 pts each [VERIFY]	Compact rubric (Section 6), batch-checked
M4 in-lesson practice submission (6, ungraded in the build)	— not in a graded group [VERIFY]	0 / completion	Completion check, or fold into VR Campus Activities at teacher discretion
VR Activity (32 across the course)	VR Campus Activities	10 pts each [VERIFY]	Completion (snapshot + walkthrough present)
Module Intro / Outro Wrapper (10)	Not graded	0 pts, survey	Ungraded survey; tracked via requirements view
The Good Life Experiment (Capstone, M3)	Module Projects & the Disputatio Final	100 pts [VERIFY]	4-criterion rubric (Section 6)
Annotated Bibliography (Capstone, M4)	Module Projects & the Disputatio Final	100 pts [VERIFY]	4-criterion rubric (Section 6)
The Disputatio (Capstone, M5, course final)	Module Projects & the Disputatio Final	100 pts [VERIFY]	4-criterion rubric (Section 6) + AI Self-Assessment read (ungraded reflection)

[VERIFY] POINT VALUES. No lesson, assignment, VR activity, or capstone page in the built course states a numeric point value or a per-item time estimate. The scheme above is proposed to reproduce the syllabus's 50/30/20 split using round numbers consistent with the tier system's typical weighting logic, and should be confirmed or adjusted by the facilitator/curriculum lead before the gradebook is finalized.

6 RUBRICS FOR EVERY TEACHER-GRADED ITEM

The capstone rubric (already built into the course — reused three times)

Unusually, this course's build already contains its own consistent capstone rubric. The Module 5 Disputatio capstone states outright that it uses "the same four criteria your teacher has used across the course," and the Module 4 Annotated Bibliography capstone confirms it reuses "the same four criteria your teacher used in Module 3." Reproduce it as-is (the wording below is the Module 5 version, the fullest of the three; Module 3 and Module 4 use the identical four criteria with descriptors tailored to their own content, as summarized underneath):

CRITERION	4 – EXEMPLARY	3 – PROFICIENT	2 – DEVELOPING	1 – BEGINNING
Understanding of the material	Course concepts show up accurately where relevant; thesis/verdict is sharp	Most concepts used correctly; minor slips	Some concepts used; others missing or misapplied	Concepts barely visible; thesis/verdict vague
Quality of reasoning	Belief/argument is honestly traced from evidence to conclusion; counterarguments (where applicable) are genuinely strong and answered	Reasoning mostly sound; adequate handling of counter-evidence	Reasoning present but thin, or counterarguments are weak/strawmen	Reasoning superficial; no real engagement with counter-evidence
Clarity and precision	Video is well-paced within the target window; document is well-organized	Clear; pacing or organization slightly uneven	Skips a section, or runs notably short/long; document hard to follow	Incomplete or disorganized
Intellectual honesty	Verdict is hedged appropriately (not overclaimed); any AI assistance is openly acknowledged; gaps or limitations are named	Mostly honest; citations/AI acknowledgment present	Some unverified/overclaimed elements; acknowledgment unclear	Overclaimed throughout; AI use hidden or unclear

M3 — Good Life Experiment

Understanding = uses credence/priors/posteriors/fallacies precisely. Reasoning = belief shift honestly traced prior→evidence→posterior. Clarity = 6–10 min tour, six research-paper sections, clear transitions. Honesty = verdict hedged in "red-

M4 — Annotated Bibliography

Understanding = accurate summaries using structure/inference/synthesis concepts. Reasoning = each source's credibility + contribution + gap evaluated; synthesis names real agreement/disagreement/gap. Clarity = 6–9 min tour hits all 8 stations; bibliography

M5 — The Disputatio (course final)

Understanding = concepts from all five modules appear where appropriate. Reasoning = three counterarguments are genuinely strong, responses real, fact-check log complete. Clarity = 7–10 min tour, well-organized document, clear position. Honesty = every

marble" language, one fallacy avoided is named, admits what they'd change.

organized. Honesty = citations correct, AI assistance acknowledged, source-set gaps named (rewarded, not penalized).

load-bearing claim verified or cut; AI use openly reflected on in the Self-Assessment.

Paste this rubric into each capstone's Canvas assignment as a native **Canvas Rubric** so it scores directly in SpeedGrader.

Free-response quiz questions

This course's build does not include a separate auto-graded or free-response Canvas Quiz beyond the 10 ungraded survey-mode wrappers (Section 2). All evaluative comprehension work happens inside the ungraded, immediately-scored lesson widgets, not in a scored quiz. There is therefore no free-response answer-guide needed for this course as built. If a facilitator later adds a comprehension quiz to a module, apply the same 3–4-criteria logic used below for the Weekly Written Assignment rubric.

Weekly Written Assignment rubric (proposed — the build has no scored rubric on these pages)

[VERIFY]. None of the ~26 non-capstone written assignments carry a scored rubric table in the build — each page gives clear instructions (a checklist of what to include) but no point-level breakdown. Because these assignments are 50% of the grade across roughly 26 items, they need a compact, fast rubric to stay batch-gradable (~1–2 min/student). Proposed:

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Full credit — Substantive	20/20	All required parts present; the student's own reasoning is visible, specific, and engages with the actual prompt (not generic filler)
Partial credit — Adequate	14/20	Required parts present but thin, generic, or missing one component
Minimal credit — Incomplete	6/20	Rushed, off-prompt, largely filler, or an insincere attempt per the syllabus's completion policy

Supplemental rubric: recorded video/oral presentations

A large share of this course's deliverables are short recorded videos (VR walkthroughs, the M1 expert presentation, all three capstone tours). Use this 3-criterion rubric anywhere a recorded presentation is the deliverable, alongside the content-specific rubric above:

CRITERION	FULL CREDIT	PARTIAL CREDIT	MINIMAL CREDIT
Content accuracy	States the content correctly and completely	Mostly accurate, minor gaps	Inaccurate or missing key content
Organization/clarity	Follows the stated structure/order in a way a viewer can follow	Mostly follows structure; some jumping around	Hard to follow or skips required sections
Delivery	Within the stated time window; audible and clear	Notably short/long or hard to hear in places	Far outside the window or largely inaudible

7 ASSIGNMENTS, INTERACTIVES & THE CAPSTONES: HOW TO RUN & GRADE

No discussion forums in this build. None of the five modules contains a Canvas Discussion — every graded written product is a Word document submitted via the OneDrive tab. This section catalogs the written Assignments, VR activities, and the three capstones instead.

General grading moves, by type

- **Weekly Written Assignment (Tier 2):** batch-check against the compact rubric (Section 6); most are 1–2 short paragraphs or a filled worked-example template, so a facilitator can move quickly if they know the "full-credit shape" in advance (per-instance table below).
- **VR Activity (Tier 1):** confirm the snapshot and recorded walkthrough exist and cover the stated content; do not grade production quality.
- **Module Wrapper Quiz (Tier 4, survey):** no grading — triage per Section 2.
- **Capstone (Tier 3):** full rubric grade (Section 6) plus a short individualized comment, Ignite-AI-drafted and teacher-edited (Section 4).

Per-instance table — Weekly Written Assignments

MODULE	ASSIGNMENT	FULL-CREDIT SHAPE
M1	1. Time Management & Goal Setting	A named Quadrant-1 task, a SMART goal with all five letters marked, a task breakdown, and a weekly schedule
M1	2. Active Reading, Memory & Note-Taking	Real Cornell notes from another class + real outline-style notes from a reading assignment (photos of paper notes accepted)
M1	3. Critical Thinking, Research & Presentation	Three sources with credibility justified, a one-page cited summary, a school-appropriate "slightly controversial" argument, and a video or narrated-slideshow presentation
M1	4. Collaborative Learning, Stress & Test Prep	Three 2–4 sentence reflections (study groups, a stressful moment, last test) each naming a real experience and a concrete takeaway
M2	1. Super Clear Instructions	A task breakdown + flowchart + self-assessment against the page's own checklist (clarity/logical flow/completeness/revision)
M2	2. Communication Style Analysis	A ~150-word analysis of the two given example paragraphs, plus two rewritten versions for different audiences
M2	3. Understanding & Refining Communication	Notes from the GPT-"manager" chat simulation, a reflection, and a rewritten clear version of the original request
M2	4. "Plan B" Challenge	A real derailed-plan scenario, the actual reaction, and a concrete alternate response
M2	5. Decision Detective	The 5-step decision tool (options/outcomes/value/likelihood/pick) applied to one real decision
M2	6. Reverse-Engineering Roadmap	A real goal broken backward into steps, then re-numbered forward, with a short reflection
M2	7. Mere Opinion or Substantive?	All 7 given statements correctly categorized with a testability explanation for each
M2	8. Reflecting on Moral Claims	Two reflections: why people dismiss evaluative claims as "just opinion" (with a real bad-outcome example), and how to evaluate a stated moral claim for truthfulness
M3	1. Thawing Explanation Freeze	[VERIFY — file missing from the build, see Section 1]
M3	2. Handwashing Infographic	A one-page infographic explaining the Semmelweis findings and why the protocol mattered
M3	3. Investigate Like a Scientist	A described problem, three or more hypotheses, and a test method for each
M3	4. Degrees of Belief	Five daily-life statements with a credence % and reasoning, plus a one-week-later reflection (note: this item has a delayed due date — see workflow note in Section 10)
M3	5. Calibrating Degrees of Belief	10 statements with background knowledge + red-marble credence for each (item 10, a controversial-topic prompt, is opt-out on disclosure — do not require students to reveal their chosen issue)
M3	6. The Missing Cookie Jar	Six evidence items evaluated as supporting/undermining each suspect, with a final culprit conclusion addressing weakening evidence
M3	7. Evaluating Evidence	Three scenarios, each with the full 3-step Question-of-Evidence walkthrough and a conclusion
M3	8. Field Biology	Three sequential Bayesian updates on a mystery-animal question, with the ratio math shown
M3	9. Analyzing Fallacies	Three of ten arguments, each broken down with the 4-step Bayesian fallacy-audit method
M4	4. Resolving Ambiguities (<i>formal, graded</i>)	10 statements disambiguated (5 regular ambiguities with both meanings + the disambiguating clue; 5 deepities split into trivial-true/profound-false readings)
M4	5. Reading Between the Lines (<i>formal, graded</i>)	8 statements, each with what's assumed, what's implied, and what's possibly hidden or forgotten
M4	L1/L2/L3/L6/L7/L8 in-lesson practice (6, ungraded in the build)	Short, single-purpose write-ups (preview practice, a question web, a big-picture/details spot-check, a structure spot-check, a 3-word synthesis, a "cite it" exercise) — completion-level only; see gradebook note in Section 5
M5	1. Build Your First Argument	Two premises + conclusion for the given topic, plus a deductive/inductive analysis and a note on what's missing

MODULE	ASSIGNMENT	FULL-CREDIT SHAPE
M5	2. Practice Evaluating Arguments	Three given arguments, each taken down with a named strategy (falsify premise / show bad support / add new info) in 3–5 sentences
M5	3. Review and Refine Your Argument	Two of the Assignment-2 arguments refined (weakened conclusion and/or sharpened premise), with a sentence on why each is stronger

Per-instance table — VR Activities

All 32 VR activities are completion-scored on the same two artifacts — a snapshot and a short recorded walkthrough. Confirm these module-specific completion notes:

MODULE	VR SEQUENCE	WHAT TO CONFIRM
M1	1.1 Eisenhower Matrix · 1.2 Mnemonic Device · 1.3 Expert Presentation · 1.4 Inner Sanctum	1.1 requires two images (full matrix + ordered Quadrant-1 close-up); 1.4 has a built-in privacy accommodation — a student may submit partial/proof shots instead of the whole space, which still counts as complete
M2	2.1 Wordless Museum · 2.2 Clarity Challenge · 2.3 Fix the Miscommunication · 2.4 Creative Adaptation · 2.5 Decision Detective Round 2 · 2.6 Reverse-Engineering Roadmap · 2.7 Fact-Opinion Museum · 2.8 The Danger Zone	2.8 explicitly instructs students to "keep it SFW" — confirm the staged scene stays school-appropriate before marking complete; otherwise all 8 are straightforward completion checks
M3 (=capstone stages 1–9)	Hypothesis Hub · Scientific Predecessors · Methodology Wall · Confidence Scale · Data Collection Station · Evidence Library · Mid-Experiment Audit · Belief-Update Timeline · Fallacy Audit	These accumulate in the same persistent lab; a mid-module glance (around Stage 5) is a good early check that the daily Excel data log is actually being kept, not just the VR layer
M4 (=capstone stages 1–8)	Library Foyer · Question Wall · Source Shelves · Direct Claims Board · Inference Board · Structure Map · Connection Web · Citation Station	The six curated sources are placeholders in the current build (Section 10 build notes) — real sources need to be in place before Stage 1 opens to students
M5 (=capstone stages 1–3)	Arena & Thesis · Argument Map & Counterargument Wall · Fact-Check Station & Refinement	Stage 1's topic choice is where the contested-topic flag applies (Section 13) — this is the moment to have already sent the advance-notice script

Per-instance table — the three capstones

CAPSTONE	HOW TO GRADE THIS ONE
The Good Life Experiment (M3)	Rubric in Section 6. Full credit requires: the 6–10 minute video hits all six research-paper sections in order (Problem/Background/Methodology/Results/Analysis/Conclusion), the verdict is hedged rather than "proven," at least one fallacy the student avoided is named, and the one-page Word doc names what the student would do differently. A genuine, honestly-reported null result (the habit didn't change anything measurable) is a full-credit outcome, not a penalized one — the rubric's honesty criterion rewards this explicitly.
Annotated Bibliography (M4)	Rubric in Section 6. Full credit requires all 6 entries with Citation + Summary (names the source's text structure) + Evaluation (credibility, unique contribution, a gap), a closing synthesis paragraph naming a real agreement/disagreement/gap, and the 6–9 minute tour hitting all 8 VR stations in the stated order, ending at the bibliography wall.
The Disputatio (M5, course final)	Rubric in Section 6. Full credit requires the six-section written document (thesis, why-this-topic, cited premises, three counterarguments-and-responses, a Great Conversation map with ≥4 real sources, a fact-check log), the 7–10 minute arena defense in the stated 7-step order, and a genuinely reflective AI Self-Assessment (not graded on the rubric itself, but read — use it to check the student's account against what you observed in the video and document).

8 COACH, NOT CATCH

Your job is to move each student forward, not to detect and punish. In this course specifically:

- **Feedback names the next step, not just the error.** Lead with what's working, especially on the capstones, which ask students to take a real position and defend it — that's a vulnerable thing to do in front of a grade.

- **Allow re-attempts on Tier 1 practice.** The lesson widgets already allow unlimited retries by design (Reset buttons); extend the same spirit to a VR activity a student clearly rushed.
- **Use analytics and Ignite AI to find students who need help early** — a low confidence rating, a missed written assignment, a thin VR reflection — then reach out, not to build a case against them.
- **On suspected AI misuse** (an assignment that reads as entirely AI-generated, or a Disputatio AI Self-Assessment that doesn't match the actual submission): open a conversation, ask the student to talk through their thinking, treat it as formation. This is especially relevant given how directly the course teaches AI-and-academic-integrity in M4 Lesson 8 — a student who missteps here has usually just misapplied a lesson they haven't fully internalized yet, not committed a first offense worth escalating immediately.
- **Public model comments** (in an announcement, or a gallery walk of VR captures) highlight good thinking; they never single out weak work for public critique.
- **On a contested Disputatio topic:** your role is to grade the quality of the argument (structure, evidence, honest engagement with counterarguments), never the position taken. A well-defended position you personally disagree with should score identically to one you agree with, provided the reasoning meets the rubric.

9 WEEKLY ANNOUNCEMENT SCRIPTS

Because students are asynchronous, your announcement is your main presence. Use the reusable template below for any topic, plus the module-specific scripts and situational scripts that follow.

REUSABLE TEMPLATE — ANY TOPIC

Hi scholars! This [week/topic] we're working on [topic name] in Module [#]. Your lesson, written assignment, and VR activity are all open now — the one thing not to miss is [due item / tricky concept], due [date]. [One warm, specific line of encouragement tied to the module's content.] As always, I'm at office hours [time] if you want to talk it through.

M1 — Preparing Like an Intellectual

"This module is about building the habits that make everything else in school easier — time management, active reading, memory, and handling test stress. None of these are one-and-done; the point is to actually try the Eisenhower Matrix or the Cornell notes method on real work you already have, not just read about it."

M2 — Acting Like an Intellectual

"We're moving from communication and decision-making into some genuinely meaty territory: how to tell a fact from an opinion, and whether moral claims are just personal taste. Lessons 7 and 8 ask real philosophical questions — take your time with them, and bring your honest reaction to office hours if something doesn't sit right."

M3 — Thinking Like an Intellectual

"Your Good Life Experiment starts this module — pick your habit, start your daily data log (the Excel bridge lesson will get you set up), and don't skip a day even if the VR building feels like the fun part and the logging feels like homework. The log is the whole experiment."

M4 — Reading Like an Intellectual

"We're building your VR Research Library one layer at a time this module — previewing, questioning, reading between the lines, then synthesizing it all. By the time we get to Lesson 8 (citing sources honestly), you'll already have done most of the thinking the Annotated Bibliography asks for."

M5 — Arguing Like an Intellectual (course final)

"This is it — the Disputatio, your course final. You'll pick a real, debatable topic, build your case in a VR arena, and defend it on video. Take the counterargument step seriously: the strongest disputationes come from students who picked objections that actually worried them, not easy ones to knock down."

Situational scripts

MID-MODULE CHECK-IN, LOW CONFIDENCE

Hi [student name] — I saw your confidence rating on the last module wrapper was on the lower end. That's useful information, not a problem: it tells me exactly where to help. Want to grab 10 minutes at office hours to walk through [the specific concept they flagged] together?

PRE-CAPSTONE SCRIPT (M3, M4, M5)

Heads up, scholars: [capstone name] opens/is due soon. Before you record your final video, do a full silent walk-through of your VR build first, then a narrated practice run — most of the polish a strong submission needs comes from that second pass, not from re-recording from scratch.

RE-ENGAGEMENT NUDGE, QUIET STUDENT

Hi [student name], I noticed I haven't seen work from you in a bit. No judgment — just checking in. Is something making this module hard to get to? Reply here or come by office hours [time], whichever's easier.

10 TEACHER WORKFLOW & WORKLOAD MAP

A normal cycle, in order

- 1 Triage the most recent module's outro-wrapper analytics (~15–20 min, Section 2) if a module just closed.
- 2 Batch-grade the current round of Weekly Written Assignments against the compact rubric (Section 6) — ~2–3 hrs spread across the cycle, Tier 2.
- 3 Spot-check VR-activity submissions for completion (~0 hrs, Tier 1).
- 4 During a capstone window (M3, M4, M5): grade the capstone itself against the 4-criterion rubric, ~8–12 hrs spread across the project window, the heaviest single line item in the course.
- 5 Post the module/topic announcement (Section 9).
- 6 Answer messages; check in with any student flagged by the outro triage or by missed work.

Heavy modules — where to budget extra time

M3 — heavy

Carries the Excel-skills bridge lesson (a from-scratch Excel onboarding for likely-novice students), a genuine 9-stage capstone build across the whole module, and a daily habit-tracking discipline that spans a week or more outside of any single lesson. Budget extra office-hours time here for Excel troubleshooting.

M4 — heavy

Carries the Annotated Bibliography capstone (an 8-stage VR build + a 6-entry bibliography) and currently has placeholder source material across the project-intro/capstone/VR files that needs to be populated with real curated sources before this module can be opened to students — see the build note below.

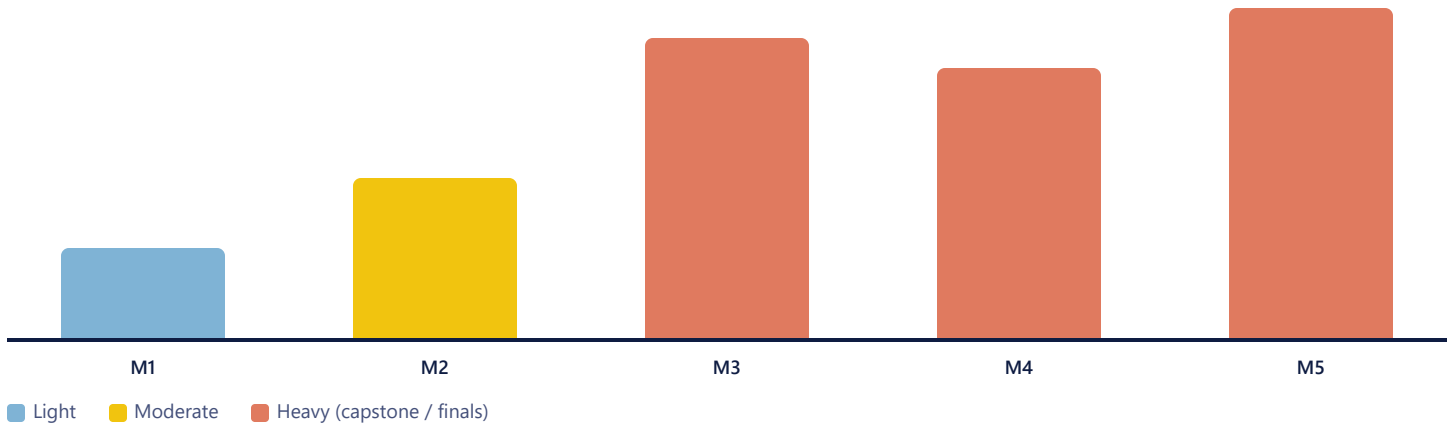
M5 — heaviest

The course final. Every student researches and defends a real position, often on a genuinely contested topic (Section 13), in a 3-part capstone (document + 7–10 min video + AI Self-Assessment) — the single heaviest per-student grading window in the course, and the one with the most sensitive-content care required going in.

M1 / M2 — lighter

No capstone in either module. M2 is content-denser (8 topics + 2 prefaces vs. M1's 4) but still runs the same lightweight Tier 2/Tier 1 rhythm throughout.

Workload across the course



Relative facilitator-grading load by module, estimated from tiered item counts and capstone presence. Plan extra time on the coral modules, and heaviest of all in the final weeks of Module 5.

Build notes for the curriculum team (not family-facing — a punch list, not a content flag)

Pre-publish items found while inventorying the build:

- **Module 3, Assignment 1** is referenced by Lesson 3.1 but the file does not exist in the course folder (Section 1).
- **Module 4's six curated sources** (the "shelves" the VR Research Library and Annotated Bibliography are built around) are placeholders ([ARTICLE/VIDEO/PODCAST/VR PLACEHOLDER]) across the project-intro, capstone, and all 8 VR files — real sources need to be selected before this module opens to students.
- **VR platform naming** ("ENGAGE" and its feature-specific vocabulary) appears throughout Modules 1–3 and in two spots in Module 4; Module 5 avoids the platform name but keeps feature-specific jargon. See the gapflag in Section 3.
- **Virtue-reflection vocabulary drifts module to module.** M1, M2, and M3 outro quizzes draw their virtue options from Optima's canonical seven (courage, courtesy, honesty, perseverance, self-government, service, responsibility). M4's outro list (Patience, Honesty, Curiosity, Discernment, Integrity) and M5's outro list (Honesty, Courage, Curiosity, Integrity, Discernment) mostly do not. Worth a short editorial pass to align all five modules to the same virtue set, or a deliberate decision that M4/M5 use a different, course-specific vocabulary and say so.
- **Module 2's "Developing Soft Skills" preface** is written in a casual first-person voice ("I will outline...", "you're welcome for this training") that doesn't match the neutral, third-person prose voice used everywhere else in the build, including the companion "Normativity" preface. Minor, but worth a light pass.

► ADAPTING TO A LIVE 4-DAY-PER-WEEK CLASS

The course above is built for asynchronous, self-paced delivery: one topic (lesson + written assignment + VR activity) at a time, no fixed weekly day-labels. Some facilitators teach this course Live, meeting students four days a week. Nothing needs to be cut to fit a 4-day schedule — every topic's three pieces (lesson, assignment, VR) already sit comfortably across four days once you add guided instruction and peer workshop time. The general shape below applies to any topic in any module; the module notes underneath address where the shape needs to flex.

The general 4-day template (any topic, any module)

LIVE DAY	IN CLASS	INDEPENDENT / HOMEWORK
Day 1	Mini-lecture on the lesson's hook and content; run the ungraded "quick check-in" widget as a class discussion instead of solo clicking; introduce the AI-awareness callout as a talking point.	Finish the lesson's evaluative "Try It" widget individually if class time runs short.
Day 2	Guided VR activity, done together: walk students through building the staged scene as a class (each student in their own headset/space), narrate the steps live instead of having each student read them solo.	Each student records their own snapshot + walkthrough video individually and submits.
Day 3	Workshop time on the written Assignment: students draft in class, then trade with a partner for a quick peer-feedback pass before finalizing.	Finish and submit the written Assignment.
Day 4	Wrap-up: a few students share their VR captures or written work; address common confusions live; preview next topic.	—

Nothing is dropped: the lesson, both widgets, the written Assignment, and the VR activity all still happen every week — the only change is that Days 1–2 move guided/whole-class content earlier, freeing Days 3–4 for workshop and wrap-up.

One representative week from each module

Module 1 (light) — Lesson 1: Time Management & Goal Setting

Day 1: Mini-lecture on the Eisenhower Matrix + SMART goals; guided practice with the "Sort into the Right Quadrant" widget as a class.
Day 2: Guided VR session — build the Eisenhower Matrix in VR together (this is explicitly "Step 1" of a two-part workflow that continues into the written assignment, so doing it together on Day 2 sets up Day 3 cleanly).
Day 3: Workshop time — students turn their Quadrant-1 task into a SMART goal and build a weekly schedule (Assignment Steps 2–3), with a partner check on whether all five SMART letters are present.
Day 4: Wrap-up — a few students share their schedules; discuss the AI-and-goals callout; preview Lesson 2 (active reading/memory).

Module 2 (dense, 8 topics + 2 prefaces) — Lesson 3: Communication Gone Wrong

Day 1: Mini-lecture on the transactional model of communication; guided discussion of the six characteristics using real classroom/group-project examples.
Day 2: Guided VR session — "Fix the Miscommunication": pair students to build a "before" broken scene and an "after" fixed scene together rather than solo.
Day 3: Workshop time on Assignment 3 (the GPT-"manager" chat simulation) — students work through the simulated confusing instructions individually, then compare notes with a partner before writing the reflection.
Day 4: Wrap-up + preview. *Compression note:* because M2 packs 8 topics + 2 short prefaces into roughly 9–10 weeks (Section 1), pair each short preface with the lesson immediately following it in the same week rather than giving it its own week — Preface: Soft Skills pairs naturally with Lesson 1, and Preface: Normativity pairs with Lesson 7.

Module 3 (heavy, capstone-spanning) — Lesson 5: Calibrating Degrees of Belief

Day 1: Mini-lecture on the red-marble credence method; guided practice with the linguistic-shorthand mapping (very sure/sure/unsure, etc.).
Day 2: Guided VR session — Data Collection Station: this is the week daily Excel logging begins, so walk through the first data entry together as a class.
Day 3: Workshop time on Assignment 5 (10 statements, red-marble credence) with peer feedback.
Day 4: Wrap-up + a 2-minute daily data-log check-in (repeat this 2-minute check at the start of every live day for the rest of the module — the Good Life Experiment habit runs all 7 days, not just the 4 live ones, so a short standing check keeps it visible). *Special weeks:* the Excel bridge lesson (between topics 4 and 5) is self-contained with no VR or written assignment — give it its own dedicated Day 1–2 session (it's stated to take ~45 minutes) rather than splitting it across the template. The final capstone week(s) should run Day 1 finalize the data log and practice walk, Day 2 record the narrated 6–10 minute video, Day 3 peer-review videos in pairs before final submission, Day 4 course-appropriate wrap-up and Module 3 outro quiz.

Module 4 (heavy, capstone-spanning) — Lesson 4: Reading the Lines (the first formally graded lesson)

Day 1: Mini-lecture on ambiguity and "deepities" (the Dennett concept); guided practice with the "Deepity or Not?" widget as a class.
Day 2: Guided VR session — Direct Claims Board, built together on the shared curated-source set.
Day 3: Workshop time on the formal Assignment 4 (Resolving Ambiguities) — this and Lesson 5's Assignment 5 are the only two formally graded assignments in the module, so give these two workshop days a slightly more feedback-intensive peer-review pass than the practice-only weeks.
Day 4: Wrap-up + preview. *Lighter weeks (Lessons 1, 2, 3, 6, 7, 8):* same template, but Day 3's "workshop" is on the short in-lesson practice write-up rather than a formal graded assignment — keep it quick. *Capstone week(s):* Day 1 finalize all 6 bibliography entries, Day 2 workshop the synthesis paragraph in pairs, Day 3 record the library tour video, Day 4 wrap-up and Module 4 outro quiz.

Module 5 (light on topic count, heaviest at the end) — Lesson 1: Basics of Argumentation

Day 1: Mini-lecture on premises/conclusion and deductive vs. inductive arguments; guided practice with the "Deductive or Inductive?" widget.

Day 2: Guided VR session — Arena & Thesis: demonstrate choosing a Location and posting a thesis as a class, then let each student build their own arena around their own topic.

Day 3: Workshop time on Assignment 1 (Build Your First Argument) with peer feedback.

Day 4: Wrap-up + preview Lesson 2 (evaluating arguments). *Capstone week(s) — the course final:* Day 1 finalize the written argument document and fact-check log in class, with a peer check on whether the three counterarguments are genuinely strong (not strawmen); Day 2 record the 7–10 minute VR arena defense (stagger recording slots across the day if class-sized); Day 3 complete the AI Self-Assessment and hold brief individual check-ins; Day 4 course-final wrap-up: whole-course virtue reflection, the Module 5 outro quiz, and a closing celebration of the disputatio tradition the students just took part in.

11 STANDARDS COVERAGE MAP

[VERIFY] BEFORE FINALIZING. Florida course 1700100 is officially titled "M/J Critical Thinking, Problem Solving, and Learning Strategies" on its CPALMS course page (cpalms.org/Public/PreviewCourse/Preview/2430). CPALMS's verified course description: "The purpose of this course is to enable students to develop learning strategies, critical-thinking skills, and problem-solving skills to enhance their performance in academic and nonacademic endeavors," with content including "strategies for acquiring, storing, and retrieving information." CPALMS states this course's standards baseline is **FLORIDA'S B.E.S.T. ELA EXPECTATIONS (EE) AND MATHEMATICAL THINKING AND REASONING STANDARDS (MTRS)** — as a general-education/study-skills course, it does not carry subject-specific benchmark codes the way a literature or science course does (no LAFS/SS/SC codes apply). The CPALMS course page is JavaScript-rendered, and the itemized EE/MTR benchmark codes could not be extracted from it in this research pass. **THE MAP BELOW IS BUILT AROUND THE VERIFIED COURSE DESCRIPTION AND COMPETENCIES, MAPPED TO WHAT THE COURSE ACTUALLY TEACHES. CONFIRM THE ITEMIZED EE.X.X / MTR.X.X BENCHMARK-CODE-LEVEL MAPPING AGAINST THE LIVE CPALMS PAGE BEFORE FINALIZING THIS MANUAL FOR DISTRIBUTION.** No specific benchmark codes are stated below because none could be verified — do not treat any code as confirmed unless checked directly against CPALMS.

By competency (verified course description → module)

COMPETENCY (FROM THE VERIFIED CPALMS COURSE DESCRIPTION)	TAUGHT IN	ASSESSED IN
Learning strategies: time management, goal-setting, active reading, note-taking, memory, test preparation	Module 1 (all 4 lessons)	Assignments 1–4, VR 1.1–1.4
Communication and adaptation to audience/situation	Module 2, Lessons 1–6 ("Developing Soft Skills")	Assignments 1–6, VR 2.1–2.6
Distinguishing facts from opinions; substantive vs. mere claims	Module 2, Lessons 7–8 ("Normativity")	Assignments 7–8, VR 2.7–2.8
Scientific reasoning: hypotheses, evidence, calibrated confidence, Bayesian updating	Module 3, Lessons 1–8	Assignments 2–9, the Good Life Experiment capstone
Identifying faulty reasoning and logical fallacies	Module 3, Lesson 9	Assignment 9, VR 3.9
Close reading: previewing, questioning, inferring, structure, summarizing/synthesizing	Module 4, Lessons 1–3, 5–7	In-lesson practice, VR 4.1–4.7, the Annotated Bibliography capstone
Finding, evaluating, and citing sources with academic integrity	Module 4, Lesson 8	The Annotated Bibliography capstone
Building, evaluating, and refining an argument; defending a position against counterargument	Module 5, all 3 lessons	Assignments 1–3, the Disputatio capstone

By module (quick reference)

MODULE	COMPETENCY AREA CARRIED
M1	Learning strategies & self-management (EE/MTR baseline — study skills)
M2	Communication, adaptability, decision-making; then facts/opinions and moral reasoning (EE baseline — reasoning and argument evaluation)
M3	Scientific and probabilistic reasoning, evidence evaluation, fallacy identification (MTR baseline — mathematical/logical reasoning)
M4	Close reading, synthesis, source evaluation, citation (EE baseline — reading and information literacy)
M5	Argument construction, evaluation, and defense (EE/MTR baseline — reasoning and communication)

12 WHAT MAKES THIS COURSE CLASSICAL & CULTIVATING CULTURE

What makes it classical

- **The disputatio, named and historically framed.** Unlike most Optima courses, which use a classical practice without naming it, Module 5 explicitly teaches the disputatio as what it is: "a structured intellectual debate... one of the oldest practices in scholarly tradition," tracing it to medieval universities where "a student would defend a thesis, anticipate counterarguments, and respond to them in real time." The capstone closes by placing the student's own defended argument in that thousand-year line, "from medieval Paris and Oxford through every serious thinker since." This is a deliberate exception to Optima's usual "teach the lesson, not the method" convention — here, the method *is* the lesson, and its lineage is the point.
- **The Great Conversation, as a named recurring construct.** Module 5 asks students to find "the great conversation" on their chosen topic — the named debates, schools of thought, and thinkers who came before — using AI to map the landscape and their own verification to walk it. Module 4, Lesson 3 makes an adjacent classical argument for reading old texts on their own terms (citing C.S. Lewis's "chronological snobbery" and naming Plato, Jane Austen, and Frederick Douglass as examples of ideas that "still speak today").
- **Wonder before mechanism, in a modest form.** Several lessons open with a real story rather than a definition — Ignaz Semmelweis and childbed fever (Module 3), a heist-movie analogy for reverse-engineering (Module 2), a detective mystery for evidence evaluation (Module 3) — before naming the underlying concept. This course's classical character leans toward the disputatio/Great-Conversation/reasoning tradition rather than a great-books literary canon; be accurate with families about that emphasis rather than overselling a literary-canon framing the course doesn't carry.
- **The virtue thread** is present in every module's outro wrapper as an explicit reflection item, though the specific virtues named drift across modules (Section 10 build note) — worth a light alignment pass, but the practice of asking students to name where a virtue showed up "in a real moment, not a generality" is itself a sound classical habit of self-examination.

Cultivating culture asynchronously

- **Spotlight real student thinking, publicly, on the merits.** Given how much of this course's output is video (VR walkthroughs, presentations, the capstones), a rotating "best Disputatio argument" or "best Good Life Experiment finding" spotlight in an announcement gives students a real audience beyond the grade.
- **Model curiosity in your own announcements.** When you triage an outro's "still unclear" responses, name the confusion honestly and treat it as an interesting problem, not a failure — especially around Module 2's moral-facts content and Module 5's contested topics, where modeling genuine intellectual openness matters most.
- **Hold the virtue thread visible.** Reference the module's virtue-reflection theme in your announcement for that module (Section 9's scripts do this), so it reads as a running thread across the year rather than a quiz question students answer once and forget.
- **Treat feedback as relationship, especially on the capstones.** A student who just spent a week defending a real position in VR has done something more exposed than filling in a worksheet; individualized, Ignite-AI-drafted-and-teacher-edited feedback (Section 4) is where that relationship is built at scale.

13 SENSITIVE-CONTENT FLAGS & FAMILY/STUDENT SCRIPTS

WHERE	WHAT	NOTICE LEVEL
Module 1, Assignment 3	Open-ended "slightly controversial argument" on a self-chosen topic (explicitly bounded "keep it SFW")	Teacher-awareness only — script below optional
Module 2, Lessons 7–8 (Facts vs. Opinions; Moral Facts)	Teaches a specific philosophical position (moral realism against relativism) as settled, using slavery, genocide, and the Trans-Atlantic slave trade as abstract, non-graphic illustrative examples	Advance family notice recommended
Module 2, Lesson 5 / Module 4, Lesson 5	A logic example referencing a ship's captain's past alcohol use (implicature teaching device, non-graphic)	Teacher-awareness only, no script needed
Module 1, Lesson 3	Uses invented, fictional political-party names ("Reprocrat"/"Demublican") to teach ad hominem — deliberately non-partisan	Teacher-awareness only, no script needed
Module 5, the Disputatio topic list	14 self-selected debate topics, several genuinely contested (animal testing ethics, immigration/refugee policy, athlete political protest, colonial-empire ethics, American Revolution legitimacy, AI/artist-labor displacement), publicly defended on video	Advance family notice strongly recommended — the single biggest flag in the course

ADVANCE NOTICE — MODULE 2, FACTS/OPINIONS AND MORAL FACTS

Hi families, in the next few weeks your student's Critical Thinking course reaches a unit on facts, opinions, and moral reasoning. The lessons argue directly that some claims (including moral claims like "slavery was wrong") are more than personal opinion, and use historical examples like slavery and genocide, discussed abstractly and without graphic detail, to make that case. This is a deliberate part of the course's approach to reasoning, not an aside — and it's a great one to talk through at home. If you have questions about how the material is presented, I'm glad to walk through it with you at [office hours / contact info](#).

ADVANCE NOTICE — MODULE 5, THE DISPUTATIO

Hi families, your student is entering the final module of Critical Thinking Skills, which culminates in the Disputatio — a researched argument they build and defend themselves in a VR arena, recorded on video. Students choose their own topic from a list that includes some genuinely debatable subjects (for example: the ethics of animal testing, immigration policy, whether professional athletes should be able to protest politically, and how we should judge historical empires). We grade the quality of the argument — structure, evidence, honest engagement with counterarguments — never the position taken. If you'd like to know which topic your student has chosen, or want to talk through the assignment before they start, reach out any time at [contact info](#).

M/J Critical Thinking Skills · Florida course 1700100 · Teacher Manual, built 2026-07-16 from the finished course build (all 5 modules), the 2026–2027 syllabus, and the CPALMS course page. Facilitator copy — not for student distribution. Re-render this manual from its companion HTML source whenever the course build changes.